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Congress Socialist Party[1]

FROM an objective point of view, the formation of the Congress Socialist Party is a legitimate and natural reaction against the move towards the Right which Congress policy adopted last year. The 'Parliamentary policy' of the Congress to-day as represented by the Parliamentary Board is, in my humble opinion, somewhat different in character from the 'Swarajist policy' as represented by the Swaraj Party in 1923-24. The Swaraj Party in those days did represent a dynamic force in the country though there were moderate elements in that party. But the Parliamentary Board does not. In these circumstances, if there had not been a revolt within the Congress against a swing to the Right,—then one would have been justified in thinking that the Congress was dying. But because the Congress was neither dead nor dying, the revolt did take place and the Congress Socialist Party came into existence. To attempt to suppress the Party or brow-beat its members with the threat of disciplinary action, shows a woeful lack of knowledge of the elementary principles of modern politics. This attempt was made in 1923 when the Swaraj Party was born and it only served to strengthen that party and add to its importance. I dare say that history is going to repeat itself now.

While the instinct that has urged the formation of the Congress Socialist Party is correct, I am afraid that there is some lack of clarity in the ideas of the party. In the first place, the choice of the name of the Party has been an unhappy one. 'Socialism' to-day has different complexions and therefore different connotations when used by different people. And there seems to be hardly anything in common between the Socialism of Mr. Ramsay MacDonald and the militant policy and method of the Socialists of

[1] Full text of a letter to the United Press of India from Vienna and published in Indian papers on the 15th March, 1935.